

External possession constructions in Laki

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Some Western Iranian languages exhibit external possession constructions, represented by a bound pronoun on the verb. This reflects a historical construction in which the possessive NP is the direct object of a past-tense transitive construction. Additionally, Laki features an external possession construction that is peculiar to this language, in which the possessor is a 3SG bound pronoun originating from historical genitive/dative clitics. This construction cuts across the tense and transitivity of the clause and deviates from the expected cross-linguistic patterns in several respects: (i) the external possessor is restricted to the third person; (ii) it occurs regularly with stative predicates, e.g. copula constructions, and hence external possession cannot be explained by the affectedness condition alone; (iii) the body is a crucial domain for the accessibility of external possession, overshadowing the affectedness condition. Providing evidence from an understudied language, the findings of this paper expand the typology of external possession.

Keywords: affectedness condition, inalienable possession, body-part domain; animacy hierarchy, person

1. Introduction

External possession (EP) refers to a construction in which the possessor (PR) does not occur NP-internally on the possessum (PM) but is realised externally in the clause, e.g., as a direct argument of the verb. In other words, the PR does not occur in the same constituent as the PM. For instance, in (1), the possessor modifier *dem Kind* appears outside of the NP:

(1) German (Haspelmath 1999: 109)

Die Mutter wusch dem Kind die Haare
the mother washed the.DAT child the.ACC hairs
'The mother washed the child's hair.'

In (1), the external possessor (EPR) is a dative argument of the clause, hence the designation 'Dative external possession' in the literature.

Typologically speaking, external possession constructions (EPCs) show variability in several essential respects (cf. Payne & Barshi 1999: 8-14), summarised as follows:

I. The grammatical relation of the PR:

The external possessor can take different grammatical relations, e.g., dative (cf. 1), direct object, and topic.

II. The grammatical relation and the semantic role of the PM:

The PMs in EPCs are generally in grammatical relations such as direct objects, unaccusative subjects, and/or indirect objects (e.g., affected goals) that indicate affected semantic roles. EPCs with the PM being an unergative or a transitive subject are rare.

III. The range of participating predicate types

Predicates such as wash and beat, conveying greater affectedness on the PR, tend to allow external possession. Stative verbs and verbs of perception often exclude external possessors (König & Haspelmath 1997: 533)

IV. Semantics of the PR and the PM

In some languages, the accessibility of the EPC depends on whether a relation of inalienable possession exists between the PR and the PM. EP is typically allowed when the PM is in a part-whole relation with the PR, e.g., a body part.

V. The semantics of the PR

External possession shows an overwhelming tendency to be accessible with animate and human PRs. In addition, first and second personal pronouns take precedence over third person pronouns in being External possessors.

A more detailed discussion of these variables will be deferred to section (5), where Laki's second type of EPCs is discussed. For the time being, it is important to note that a single 'affectedness condition' can reflect most of the variables discussed above, such that EP is favoured if (i) the possessor is affected by the action of the predicate, (ii) the syntactic role of the possessive NP is one involving affected semantic roles (e.g. unaccusative subjects but not transitive subjects); (iii) the semantic relation between the PM and the PR is inalienable (e.g. body part) since an effect on the PM usually means an effect on the PR, and (iv) the predicate denotes an effect or change of state. Affectedness as a conditioning factor for the accessibility of EPCs can mean not only physical affectedness but also mental affectedness (cf. Haspelmath's discussion of Spanish EPCs 1999: 112). In fact, it has been suggested that mental affectedness is a more crucial factor with relevance for external possession. In the following example, the EPR is only mentally affected by the action of the verb:

(2) Russian (Haspelmath 1999: 109)

On njančil mne detej.

He babysat me.DAT children.ACC

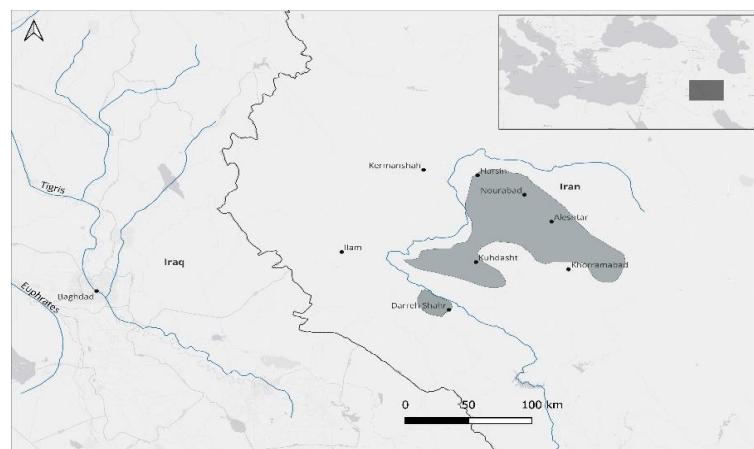
'He babysat my children.'

This paper studies EPCs in Laki, a Western Iranian language. The data for this study come from 12 narratives (around 70 minutes of running speech) collected in the field in 2017-2018, and additional translation tasks.¹ The recordings feature Pear Story narrations and spontaneous speech between speakers. Some spoken narratives from this corpus have been used to describe Laki's system of person clitics in Mohammadirad (2020a: 33).

It is seen that Laki's second type of EPCs shows an important divergence from similar phenomena in Indo-European languages, further expanding the typology of EPCs. In so doing, Sections 2 and 3 give a brief overview of Laki and EP in older stages of Iranian, respectively. Section 4 presents the first type of EPC found in Laki. Section 5, as the focus of this paper, gives a detailed investigation of Laki's second type of EPCs, which, as stated above, is specific to the PR being a 3SG person clitic. Section 6 is the discussion.

2. Laki and its linguistic ecology

Laki is an Iranian language spoken mainly in the Zagros regions of western Iran. In the traditional taxonomy of Iranian, Laki is considered a member of the northwestern branch, along with the neighbouring Kurdish to the north. To the south, it is neighbour to various varieties of Luri, a southwest Iranian language. This has led to conflicting views on the linguistic and ethnic affiliation of Laki, as it is sandwiched between the southeast Kurdish cultural complex and the northwest edge of the Luri complex (cf. Anonby 2004 for discussion). Figure (1) illustrates the approximate location of Laki-speaking areas according to Fattah (2000: vi).



¹I am indebted to Younes Garousi, a native speaker of Laki Kakevandi, and Alireza Nadri, a native speaker of Laki Aleshtar, for their generous help in collecting spoken narratives. Younes kindly answered my many questions on his native dialect.

Figure 1: Approximate distribution of Laki-speaking areas.

Laki is an endangered language. It has no official status, further leading to its marginalisation. In major urban localities, the shift to Persian is taking an increasing pace. The number of speakers is estimated to be around one million. However, this figure should be treated cautiously as there is no reliable census.

Laki has a basic SOV word order. Genitives and adjective modifiers follow the head noun in the structure of the NP. Laki features a mixed adpositional typology; thus, prepositions, postpositions, and circumpositions occur in roughly the same proportion in the language. Like most Iranian languages, Laki is characterised by a high frequency of light verb constructions, e.g., *piř kirdin* ‘to fill’ (lit. ‘full to do’).

Laki is characterised by tense-sensitive alignment: the agreement pattern is nominative-accusative in verbs derived from the present stem but ergative in verbs derived from the past stem.

The varieties investigated in this paper are Kakavandi and Aleshtari. A Brief grammatical description of Laki Aleshtar is available in Lazard (1992). Belelli (2020) provides some notes on the grammar of Laki Kakevandi. These dialects comprise what can be termed ‘Proper Laki, as opposed to transitional mixed Laki dialects in the northern periphery, which have lost tense-sensitive alignment and other typical Laki features due to contact with different vernaculars of Southern Kurdish.’²

3. External possession in earlier stages of Iranian

External possessors occur in two constructions in ancient Indo-European Languages: external dative possessors, and double case constructions. The Indo-European external possessor has a beneficiary meaning inherited from Proto-Indo-European (Luraghi 2020: 179). Similarly, in Old Iranian, the EPR is not syntactically differentiable from benefactives or experiencers, rendering the semantic interpretation vague (Haig 2008: 63). In the EPCs of Old Iranian languages, the EPR is a nominal/pronominal element in the genitive case (syncretised with the dative in Old Persian), see (3), available also as a clause-second genitive/dative clitic pronoun, cf. (4).

(3) Old Persian (Haig 2008: 64)

Aspačanā vačabara Dārayavahauš xšāyaθiyahyā isuvām dārayati
 Aspathines bow-bearer Darius.GEN king.GEN battle_axe.ACC holds
 ‘Aspathines, bow-bearer, holds the battle-axe of Darius the King.’

(4) Old Avestan (Yasna 29)

kām=hōi uštā ahurəm?
 whom=3SG.F.DAT.GEN wish.PRS.2SG lord.ACC

²See Belelli (2021) for a grammatical description of Laki Harsini, a transitional Laki dialect

‘Whom did you wish to be her lord?’

In (3), the EPR is in the genitive case while the PM is in the accusative case (compare with ex. 1). In (4), the dative³ external possessor is realised as a person clitic in the clause-second position.

EPCs continued to occur in Middle Iranian languages. In West Middle Iranian,⁴ the external possessor is characterized by the PM being a direct object in past transitive tenses and the PR being realised externally next to the verb as a verbal person affix merged with the copula stem. The person ending paradigm later underwent univerbation in modern Iranian languages.

(5) Middle Persian (MacKenzie 1999: 305)

čiyon=it⁵ fradom ham bahr ud rōzīg bē abgand hēm
 since=2SG:A first both portion and Substance PVB throw.PST COP.1SG
 ‘Since you have first overthrown both my portion and daily substance.’

While a continuation of the dative EPR of the Old Iranian, this type of EPC reflects ergativity in the past transitive tenses in a way that the EPR’s non-local realisation is only possible in past transitive tenses. In addition, in a significant shift from Old Iranian, the PR is realised as a verbal person affix instead of a person clitic (historically derived from genitive/dative clitics). This system of argument indexing arose as a result of affix co-optation in past transitive tenses, meaning that the object agreement affix degrammaticalised into a bound pronoun and was co-opted for marking benefactives, preposition complements, and possessors (cf. Haig 2018 for discussion). As seen in the next section, this type of EPC recurs in Laki and some modern West Iranian languages.

4. Type 1 external possession construction in Laki

There are two constructions featuring external possession in Laki. The first construction is a continuation of the pattern seen in Middle West Iranian: The EPR is realised as a bound person affix instead of a person clitic; see Table 1 for the paradigm of person clitics and

³See (Mohammadirad & Rasekh-Mahand 2018) For a study of the semantic map of dative markers in Iranian languages.

⁴The typical characteristics of West Middle Iranian languages (Middle Persian and Parthian) is the reduction of nominal case morphology to a two-term case system, i.e. direct vs. oblique, and the merging of Old Iranian genitive/dative and accusative clitic pronouns to a single oblique clitic paradigm. The clitic paradigm grammaticalized as markers of transitive subject agreement in most modern languages, but otherwise retained their mobility. Another major shift in Middle Iranian is the restructuring of the verbal system in a way that the resultative participle became the sole way of expressing past tense verb forms. Accordingly, the argument structure related to the resultative participle was extended to the past transitive constructions, meaning that the resultative participle would agree with the direct case marked object argument of the transitive clause, as it would agree with the intransitive subject. This led to the rise of ergativity in Middle Iranian languages and later in offspring languages. (cf. Haig 2008; 2018 for an overview).

⁵The function of each bound person index is separated by a colon in the gloss after its person and number, hence, A: subject of past transitive verb; O: object; POSS: possessor; NC: non-canonical subject; R: adpositional complement.

verbal person suffixes.

	verbal person affixes	person clitics
1SG	-im	=m
2SG	-īn	=t
3SG	-ē(t)	=ē, =ī
1PL	-īmin	=mān, =mon
2PL	-īnān	=tān, =ton, =īno ⁶
3PL	-in	=an, =n

Table 1: Bound person markers in Laki

As in Middle West Iranian, external possession is limited to the past transitive tense. The workings of this sub-type of EPC are such that only when the possessive NP is a direct object can the PR occur externally on the verb as a verbal person agreement suffix. The following examples illustrate modern examples of type 1 EPCs in Laki. It is notable that the body part PM in (6) does not need to be definite-marked on account of its inherent definiteness.

- (6) *das=t-a* *ma-girt-im*
 hand=2SG:A=IPFV IPFV-hold.PST-1SG:POSS
 ‘You would take my hand.’ (Mohammadirad 2020a: 383)
- (7) *āyl-ēl-a=n* *bird-im*
 child-PL-DEF=3PL:A take.PST-1SG:POSS
 ‘They took (away) my children.’ (Mohammadirad 2020a: 383)
- (8) *kwöl šakar-a=m* *hwārd-īn*
 all sugar-DEF=1SG:A eat.PST-2SG:POSS
 ‘I ate all your sugar.’

In the above examples, the transitive subject (A) is expressed by the person clitics, which, following the clitic placement rule, land on the first stressed constituent within the VP as their host, i.e., the direct object NP. On the other hand, the PR is distant from its PM and is expressed by a bound person affix on the verb.

⁶The form =īno is specific to the Aleshtar dialect (Lazard 1999)

The external possession of this kind is limited to bound PRs. With nominal PRs, internal possession is the norm:

- (9) [*šakar-a=y Mīnā=m*]_{O,NP} *hwārd*
 sugar-DEF=EZ PN=1SG eat.PST
 ‘I ate Mina’s sugar.’

EPCs of this sort also occur in neighbouring Kurdish languages such as the Hawrami dialect of Gorani and most Central Kurdish dialects:⁷

- (10) Hawrami (MacKenzie 1966: 53)
bāxča-ka=š di-aymē
 garden-DEF=3SG see.PST-1PL
 ‘He saw our garden.’

- (11) Central Kurdish (MacKenzie 1961: 115)
bačka-(e)kān=ī a-xwārd-im
 child-DEF.PL=3SG IPFV-eat.PST-1SG
 ‘It used to eat my children.’

Discussing similar phenomena in the Mukri dialect of Central Kurdish, Öpengin (2013) attributes the external realisation of the PR to alignment constraints which restrict the number of clitics in each cliticisation domain to one (cf. Woolford 2003) and the competition between clitics to occur in the left-most edge of the cliticisation domain, in this case the VP. Under the first case, there is a constraint on clitic clusters, and only the higher-ranked argument, i.e., the A, will retain its morphophonological form. In contrast, the PR must change into a different morphophonological form, in this case, the verbal person affix. Under the second constraint, A takes precedence over PR in appearing at the left-most edge of the VP, so PR must occur externally. Similar formal accounts have been proposed for Laki’s EPCs (cf. Taghipour and Kahnemuyipour 2021).

A peculiarity of Laki among Iranian languages with similar EPCs is that when the agent is third person singular, the co-indexing agent clitic exceptionally takes the verb as its host (see 12). Nonetheless, the possessor is realised as a verbal person affix on the verb instead of appearing locally on its PM:

- (12) *das girt-m=ē*
 hand take.PST-1SG:POSS=3SG:A

⁷See Öpengin & Mohammadirad (2022) for an overview of Kurdish varieties featuring external possession.

- (16) [*kitow Mīnā*]_{POSS.NP} *sīya=s*
 book PN black=COP.3SG
 ‘Mina’s book is black.’

It is unclear how this EPC specific to 3SG arose historically, but given its absence in neighbouring Iranian languages, it could be that Laki developed it independently. However, not all 3SG PRs are subject to external realisation. In what follows, I draw on typological parameters discussed in Section 1 to discuss the conditions triggering EPCs with a 3SG PR.

5.1 The grammatical relation of the PR

The EPR in type 2 Laki EPCs can be only a bound 3SG pronoun realised on the verb as an enclitic. In other words, the bound 3SG EPR does not assume any argument relation in the verb’s argument structure. Historically, the pronominal clitics derive mainly from Old Iranian genitive/dative clitic pronouns. The extension to the possession domain is reasonable from the genitive/dative origin.

- (17) *dā īma, sidā nāzuk=as=ē*
 mother 1PL voice soft=COP.3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘Our mother, her voice is nice.’

- (18) *harke ma-hat=ē=a hwāzmānī*
 whoever IPFV-come.PST.3SG=3SG:POSS=DRCT betrothal
 ‘Whosoever came to ask her hand (lit. her betrothal).’

On the other hand, nominal PRs are not subject to external realisation:

- (19) [*asb pīyā-a*]_{POSS.NP} *rangīn bī-ø*
 horse man-DEF beautiful COP.PST-3SG
 ‘The man’s horse was beautiful.’

Moreover, as a reflection of its historical use, the 3SG clitic pronoun (and the paradigm of clitic pronouns) can express functions such as direct object (20), agent (21), preposition complement (22), and experiencer (or non-canonical subject) (23). It is notable that in all these functions, the 3SG bound pronoun takes the verb as its host. Examples are from Mohammadirad (2020a: 379-381).

- (20) *šekār ka-n=ē*
 hunting do.PRS-3PL=3SG:O
 ‘That they hunt it,’
- (21) *golowī=a ma-činyā=y*
 pear=IPFV IPFV-pick.PST=3SG:A
 ‘He was picking pear(s).’
- (22) *sēf-ēl-a agard jam=ā ma-ka-n=ē*
 apple-PL-DEF with collection-IND IND-do.PRS-3PL=3SG:R
 ‘They collect the apples with him.’
- (23) *fira tinī-as=ē*
 very thirsty-COP.3SG=3SG:NC
 ‘He is very thirsty.’

As can be seen, the 3SG person clitic is realised on the verb regardless of its syntactic function and irrespective of the availability of potential elements to the left to host it. This further points to the endpoint of the grammaticalisation of the 3SG clitic, namely its lack of mobility. What is noticeable, though, as seen below, is that the External realisation of a bound 3SG possessor is contingent on certain semantic and syntactic factors.

5.2 The grammatical relation and the semantic role of the PM

External possession is favoured with arguments to the left on the syntactic relations hierarchy (cf. Haspelmath 1999: 113). Unergative subjects and transitive subjects do not usually allow EP.

PP (oblique prepositional phrase) < direct object < unaccusative subject < unergative subject < transitive subject

Note that the universality of the proposed hierarchy above has been questioned, especially concerning the placement of PP high on the hierarchy (cf. Payne & Barshi 1999: 11 for discussion). In what follows, I shall examine in descending order the types of syntactic relations favoured in Laki EPCs.

I. Unaccusative subjects

Unaccusative subjects are grammatical subjects of intransitive verbs. They are, however, not semantic agents of the verb. In Laki, unaccusative subjects show a strong preference for EP. The following examples denote the unaccusative subject's physical affectedness by the verb's action.

- (24) *pā=a ma-šk-ē-t=ē*
 leg=IND IND-break.PRS-3SG-EP=3SG:POSS
 'He breaks his leg.' [lit. His leg breaks]

- (25) *sər=a ma-yjit=ē*
 head=IND IND-ache.PRS.3SG=3SG:POSS
 'He has headache.' [lit. His head aches]

The examples below further point that the mental affectedness of the PR can also trigger external possession.

- (26) *asāb xirow=a ma-wt=ē*
 nerve bad=IND IND-become.PRS.3SG=3SG:POSS
 'He becomes angry.' [lit. His nerve becomes bad.]

- (27) *čam kat-ü-t=ē öw hin-ēl-a*
 eye fall.PST-be.PST-3SG=3SG:POSS DEM.DIST thing-PL-DEF
 'His eyes fell on those things.'

- (28) *zala ma-čū-t=ē*
 gallbladder IPFV-go.PST.3SG-EP=3SG:POSS
 'He got scared.' [lit. His gallbladder went off.]

Given the examples above, it can be said that both physical and mental affectedness trigger external possession in Laki.

II. Direct object

External possession is possible with certain PMs functioning as the direct object.

(29) *lam git=a may-t=ē*
 belly sew=IND IND.give.PRS-3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘She sews his belly.’

(30) *sir=a ma-šūr-im=ē*
 head=IND IND-wash.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘I am washing his hair.’

(31) *jīnāza=(a) ma-šūr-in=ē*
 corpse=IND IND-wash.PRS-3PL=3SG:POSS
 ‘They wash his corpse.’ (Belelli 2020: 98)

In the above examples, the PM is a body part, and the affectedness condition triggers the realisation of the possessor NP-externally. On the other hand, internal possession is used when the PM is an alienable object (32), kinship (33)-(34), or non-human (35). In terms of affectedness, the lack of EP is justified by the fact that the PR is not necessarily affected by the action of the verb on the PM:

(32) *öw libās-ēl-a=y=a ma-šūr-ē*
 3SG cloth-PL-DEF=3SG:POSS=IND IND-wash.PRS-3SG
 ‘She is washing his clothes.’

(33) *birā-ka=y=a ma-kuš-in*
 brother-DEF=3SG:POSS=IND IND-hit/kill.PRS-3PL
 ‘They beat his brother.’

(34) *xwaha-ka=y=a ma-ŷn-im*
 sister-DEF=3SG:POSS=IND IND-see.PRS-1SG
 ‘I see his sister.’

(35) *sag-a=y=a m-ār-īn*
 dog-DEF=3SG:POSS=IND IND-bring.PRS-2SG
 ‘You bring his dog.’

III. Oblique prepositional phrase

External possession is allowed with certain prepositional phrases. The following examples illustrate the availability of EP with PPs expressing source arguments:

- (36) *kiḷāw-a=y ē sar kat=ē*
 hat-DEF=3SG:POSS from head fall.PST.3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘His hat fell from his head.’

- (37) *ē vīr=a ma-č-ē-t=ē*
 full memory=IND IND-do.PRS-3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘He forgets.’ [lit. It goes from his memory.]

Similarly, goal arguments of a verb of caused motion, such as ‘put’ and ‘hit’, can allow the non-local realisation of the 3SG PR:

- (38) *qeyr-ē bār=a ma-n-ē-t=ī=ar kūl*
 some-INDF load=IND IND-put.PRS-3SG-EP=3SG:POSS=POST shoulder
 ‘He puts some load on his (donkey’s) shoulder(s).’

- (39) *b-a-m=ē a=pišt sar*
 IRR-give.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS at=back head
 ‘I shall hit (him) on the back of his head.’

In the example just seen, the PM is either a body part or a mental abstraction (e.g., memory in ex. 37). In both cases, the PM is in an inalienable relation with the PR. According to the affectedness condition, what triggers EP here is that an effect on the PM implies an effect on the PR, hence the external realisation of the PR.

The following examples further illustrate the availability of External possession with a PP argument which is a mental abstraction of the body part.

- (40) *ye šōw hin-ē hat=ī ē xōw*
 a night thing-INDF come.PST.3SG=3SG:POSS to dream
 ‘One night, he dreamt of a thing.’ (lit. a thing came to his sleep)

- (41) *āyl-ēl-a hāt-n=ē=a yārī*

child-PL-DEF come.PST-3PL=3SG:POSS=DRCT aid
 ‘The children came to his aid.’

However, with the PM being a member of the alienable domain, the PR is realised NP-internally.

(42) *m-an-ē=a sar čarx-a=y*
 IND-put.PRS-3SG=DRCT on bike-DEF=3SG:POSS
 ‘He puts (the apples) on his bike.’

(43) *gulowī bi-kē nām sabat-a=y*
 pear IRR-do.PRS.3SG inside basket-DEF=3SG:POSS
 ‘That he put pear(s) into his basket’

Likewise, EPCs do not occur with oblique PPs that are not within the verb’s argument structure.

(44) *va čarx-a=y hamāt-ar nām kuçk-ē*
 with bike-DEF=3SG:POSS collide.PST.3SG-down inside stone-INDF
 ‘His bike collided with a stone.’ [Lit. He collided with a stone with his bike]

The conclusion that can be drawn from this state-of-affairs is that oblique prepositional phrases allow EP as long as they are within the argument structure of the verb and are affected somehow by the action of the verb. As we have seen, this is most readily the case with the body part domain and its mental abstraction.

IV. Unergative and transitive subjects

Unergative subjects and transitive subjects have the commonality of being the semantic agent of their predicates. Put differently, these syntactic relations express non-affected semantic roles. Crosslinguistically, it is rare to find EPCs with unergative subjects¹⁰ and EPCs with transitive subjects are not attested. In Laki, too, internal possession is the unmarked pattern with unergative (45), and transitive subjects (46).

(45) *brā-yl-a=y pařī-n *brā-yl-a pařī-n=ē*
 brother-PL-DEF=3SG:POSS jump.PST-3PL
 ‘Her brothers jumped.’

¹⁰cf. In Albanian, external possession is possible with unergative subjects (see Buchholz & Fiedler 1987: 232).

- (46) *šū-a=y* *nān=a* *ma-ar-ē*
 husband-DEF=3SG:POSS food=IND IND-eat.PRS-3SG
 ‘Her husband eats food.’

V. The grammatical relation and the semantic role of the PM: summary

External possession is accessible only with a subset of grammatical relations, namely, unaccusative subjects, direct objects, and prepositional complements. These syntactic relations tend to express affected semantic roles, and the affectedness, both physical and mental, seems to trigger EP for these relations. Among these syntactic relations, external possession is most favoured with unaccusative subjects, reflecting the high affectedness of both the PR and PM with these arguments. With direct objects and oblique prepositional complements, external possession is contingent on the PM being a body part or its mental abstraction. On the other hand, EP is not allowed with unergative and transitive subjects, conforming to the crosslinguistic pattern.

The syntactic relations hierarchy proposed by Haspelmath (1999) is adapted as follows for type 2 Laki EPCs:

unaccusative subject < direct object < PP < unergative subject, transitive subject

The cut-off point for Laki EPCs is after oblique PPs. This, in turn, brings Laki together with European languages like French. In Laki EPCs, the PM is usually a body part (cf. 5.4)

5.3 The range of participating predicate types

The type of predicate is another factor triggering the availability of EPCs. Some languages, e.g., French and German, favour EPCs with change of state verbs, i.e., verbs like ‘wash’, whose action affects the arguments. Haspelmath (1999) proposes the following hierarchy for predicate types used in EPCs in European languages. The more to the left the predicate, the more likely it is to allow EPCs.

patient-affecting < dynamic non-affecting < stative

This hierarchy also applies to some non-Indo-European languages, e.g., Tsez (Schaefer 1999), but fails to apply elsewhere. For instance, in Tz’utujil, EP is preferred with unaccusative verbs (Aissen 1999).

As seen in 5.2., unaccusative verbs allow EPCs. In the same vein, stative verbs, e.g. copulas, regularly allow EPCs. In the following examples, the possessive NP is the copula subject:

- (47) *lam sangīn bī-yas=ē-yā*
 stomach heavy COP.PST-PRF=3SG:POSS=ASP
 ‘His stomach has become heavy.’
- (48) *dam garm=(a)=ē*
 mouth warm=COP.3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘He is cool.’ (lit. His mouth is warm.)¹¹
- (49) *nām šīrīn=as=ē*
 name PN=COP.3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘Her name is Shirin.’
- (50) *sidā bam nīya=s=ē*
 voice rough NEG=COP.3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘Her voice is not harsh.’
- (51) *fīrūš xū bī-t=ē*
 sale good COP.PST.3SG-EP=3SG:POSS
 ‘Its sale was good.’
- (52) *vaz fāra xu=as=ē*
 situation much good=COP.3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘He is wealthy.’ (lit. His situation is very good.)

The PM is a body part in (47)-(48), belongs to the abstract personal sphere in (49)-(50), and is an abstract nominal in (51)-(52). The external possession in these examples cannot simply be accounted for by affectedness since there is usually no effect on either the PM or the PR. This means that, at least with copula verbs, Laki is not sensitive to affectedness as a necessary condition for EP to occur.

Likewise, EP occurs when the possessive NP is the copula complement. In the following examples, the possessive NP is a body part, a kinship term, and an object, respectively.

¹¹This sentence can also be interpreted as a small clause, thus: *dam garm=ē* (mouth warm=3SG:POSS) ‘He is cool.’ (lit. His mouth (is) warm, cf. the equivalent in Persian *dam=eš garm*). This further shows that small clauses allow EP.

- (53) *tüšk-ē a das-ā bī-t=ē*
 goat-INDF in hand-POST COP.PST.3SG-EP=3SG:POSS
 ‘A goat was with him (lit. A goat was in his hands).’

- (54) *ēya=ž-a dā-s=ē*
 DEM.PROX=ADD-DEM mother=COP.3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘She is her mother.’

- (55) *ēya kilāw-a=s=ē*
 DEM.PROX hat-DEF=COP.3SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘This is his hat.’

External possession is also made possible with stative verbs such as ‘to remain’ and ‘know’:

- (56) *sir ma-mīn-ē-t=ē=a jā*
 head=IND IND-remain.PRS-3SG-EP=3SG:POSS=DRCT place
 ‘His head remains behind.’

- (57) *tu fīkr=a ma-zān-īn=ē*
 2SG thinking=IND IND-know.PRS-2SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘You know his thinking.’

- (58) *ma asāb=a ma-zān-m=ē*
 1SG nerves=IND IND-know.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘I know his nerves.’

Similarly, verbs of perception such as ‘see’ and ‘hear’ allow EP.

- (59) *dang=a ma-šnaw-m=ē*
 voice=IND IND-hear.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘I hear her voice.’

- (60) *čam-al=a m-öyn-im=ē*
 eye-PL=IND IND-see.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘I see her eyes.’

Given the regular occurrence of EPCs with copula constructions, stative verbs such as ‘remain’, ‘know’, and verbs of perception such as ‘see’ and ‘hear’, it can be said that Laki prefers EP with stative verbs. Here, affectedness has no role in triggering EP. By allowing EP, especially with stative verbs, Laki deviates from other Indo-European languages.

While the affectedness condition is irrelevant for external possession with stative predicates, EP does occur with patient-affecting predicates on the condition that both the PM and PR are affected by the verb’s action. Recall the following examples from 5.2, all having patient-affecting predicates, but only (61)-(63) allow EP. The difference is that PM is only genuinely affected by the action of the predicate in these examples with a body part PM or a personal sphere (63). The PM is not affected as such in (64)-(65).

- (61) *sir=a ma-šūr-im=ē*
 head=IND IND-wash-1SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘I am washing his hair.’
- (62) *šaš gil kīsa xwâ ma-nē-t=ē=ya šān-ā*
 six CLFsack salt IND-put.PRS-3SG=3SG:POSS=DRCT shoulder-POST
 ‘He puts six sacks of salt on his (the donkey’s) shoulder(s).’
- (63) *ye šöw hin-ē hat=ī ē xöw*
 a night thing-INDF come.PST.3SG=3SG:POSS to dream
 ‘One night, he dreamt of a thing.’ (lit. A thing came to his dream)
- (64) *ma-n-ē=a sar čarx-a=y*
 IND-put.PRS-3SG=DRCT on bike-DEF=SG:POSS
 ‘He puts (the pears) on his bike.’
- (65) *öw libās-ēl-a=y=a ma-šūr-ē*
 3SG cloth-PL-DEF=3SG:POSS=IND IND-wash.PRS-3SG
 ‘She is washing his clothes.’

Examples (66)-(68) illustrate the accessibility of EP with the non-affecting predicate ‘see’. It is noticeable that the EPR is only

possible when the PM is a body part.

(66) *das-ēl-a* *m-öyn-im=ē*
 hand-PL-DEF IND-see.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘I see his hands.’

(67) *dang=a* *ma-šnaw-m=ē*
 voice=IND IND-hear.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘I hear her voice.’

(68) *xwaha-ka=y=a* *ma-ŷn-im*
 sister-DEF=3SG:POSS=IND IND-see.PRS-1SG
 ‘I see his sister.’

In short, Laki EPCs favour stative and unaccusative verbs above all other predicates in the EPCs. The situation hierarchy works out as follows for Laki EPCs:

stative, unaccusative < patient/oblique-affecting < dynamic non-affecting

This hierarchy should be read as follows: the accessibility of EPCs is strongest to the left of the hierarchy and is conditioned by factors such as affectedness to the right. The type 2 Laki EPCs run contrary to the crosslinguistic pattern in not excluding EPR with stative verbs (cf. König & Haspelmath 1997: 533 for European languages).

5.4 Semantics of the PR and the PM

Another factor constraining the accessibility of EPCs is the relationship between the PR and the PM. Crosslinguistically, there seems to be a strong bias towards body parts as accessible possessa in EPCs. Broadly speaking, inalienable possessa are more privileged to appear in EPCs than alienable possessa. Payne and Barshi (1999: 14) suggest the following hierarchy. They further add that languages differ concerning what counts as ‘other inalienable’, ‘alienable’ and ‘non-possessable’.

body part < part-whole < other inalienable < alienable + proximate < alienable + distal < non-possessable.

Those Laki EPCs containing patient-and-oblique-affecting predicates are sensitive to the PM being a body part or an abstraction (cf.

5.3. for examples). Laki even allows EPCs with ‘dynamic non-affecting’ predicates, as long as the PM is a body part, as in (66) above, repeated here for convenience.

- (69) *das-ēl-a m-öyn-im=ē*
 hand-PL-DEF IND-see.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS
 ‘I see his hands.’

The availability of EP even with a non-affected body part in (69) points to the special place of body parts in the grammar of alienability (cf. Mithun 2001), on the one hand, and suggests that the possession of body parts is different than the possession of other entities.¹²

Similarly, in Kurmanji (Northern Kurdish) dialects, an external possession construction exists which seems to be available only with possessed body parts, as illustrated below. Like Laki, Kurmanji has a basic NG order. In the following examples, the EPR is in the externalised topic position but can still be identifiable as the genitive of *çav* and *ji bîr*, respectively.

- (70) Kurmanji
min çav lê ket
 1SG eye at_it fall.PST.3SG
 ‘My eyes fell on it.’

- (71) Kurmanji¹³
min ji bîr=e
 1SG at memory=COP.3SG
 ‘I remember.’ [Lit. It is in my memory]

Kinship terms, the most inalienable after body parts in alienability lines, are not accessible to EPC even with a patient-affecting predicate:

- (72) *birā-ka=y=a ma-kuş-in*
 brother-DEF=3SG:POSS=IND IND-hit/kill.PRS-3PL
 ‘They beat his brother.’

¹²In a few western Iranian languages, the distinction between inalienable and alienable possession is also reflected in the choice between the be-possessive type of predicative possession vs. have-possessive, cf. Mohammadirad (2020b)

¹³This example is more common in the Behdîni variety of Kurmanji. I thank Ergin Öpengin for bringing this example to my attention.

On the other hand, as seen in 5.3. in copula clauses, there is no distinction along alienability lines with respect to the accessibility of EPCs. Thus, in copula clauses, PM entities with different alienability distinctions are accessible in EPCs. Accordingly, at least with stative verbs, the relation between the PR and PM does not have relevance for the accessibility of EPCs.

5.5 The semantics of the PR

The final relevant factor to look at in the accessibility of EPCs is the status of the PR on the animacy hierarchy. Haspelmath (1999: 113) suggests the following hierarchy:

1st/2nd p. pronoun < 3rd p. pronoun < proper name < other animate < inanimate

According to this hierarchy, animate PRs take precedence over inanimate PRs in being accessible to EPCs. This is the case with EPCs in European languages. Moreover, first and second person pronouns are more amenable to EPCs than third person pronouns.

Laki's type 2 EPCs deviate from these tendencies in restricting the PR to a bound 3SG pronoun. The pronominal nature of the PR allows it to encompass both animate and inanimate PRs:

(73) *mi rū=a ma-šūr-im=ē*
 1SG face=IND IND-wash.PRS-1SG=3SG:POSS
 'I am washing her face.'

(74) *či-min=a mūza-ē alān nām balad nī=m=ē*
 go.PST-1PL=DRCT museum-IND now name known NEG=COP.1SG=3SG:POSS
 'We went to a museum. I don't know (lit. don't remember) its name now.'

(75) *xwā darāmad xū=as=ē*
 salt profit good=COP.3SG=3SG:POSS
 'As for salt, it makes good profit.' (lit. Its profit is good.)

As seen in (76), a speech act pronoun is not accessible as an EPR even with the PM being a body part and the predicate patient-affecting:

- (76) *rü=t=a* *ma-šūr-im* **rü=a ma-šūr-im=it*
 face=2SG:POSS=IND IND-wash.PRS-1SG
 ‘I am washing your face.’

The question arises then as to why Laki type 2 EPCs are restricted to the 3SG. It is known that the third person has quite distinctive properties relative to the first and second persons. For instance, the third person is not a participant in the speech act. It can be constrained to anaphoric use in some languages as opposed to the inherently deictic use of first and second persons (see Siewierska 2004: 5-8 for discussion). In addition, the 3SG person value in Laki is unspecified for gender and animacy. Technically, it is accessible to a range of PR types not available to first and second persons.

What seems to be relevant for the restriction of EPR to the 3SG person is perhaps its high tendency to appear in syntactic functions denoting affected semantic roles. For instance, the third person occurs more frequently in the direct object role than in the A (i.e., transitive subject) role (cf. Haig 2018: 810- 812). This can potentially explain why type 2 Laki EPCs are restricted to the third person as PR, meaning that the EP reflects the high frequency of the third person in affected semantic roles. This needs to be further investigated before drawing any conclusions.

Alternatively, it is possible that the grammaticalization of the 3SG person clitic could be partly the reason in the rise of the type 2 Laki EPCs. As seen in 5.1., the 3SG clitic pronoun is, by default, positioned on the verb, regardless of the syntactic function it expresses. Therefore, this grammaticalisation of the 3SG person clitic in the sense of losing mobility can possibly explain the external realisation of the 3SG PR, say, in copula clauses, where the EP is not sensitive to affectedness and inalienability distinctions between the PR and the PM.

6. Discussion

External possession in Laki is represented by a bound person index on the verb. There are two external possessor constructions. The first construction reflects a historical pattern in Middle Iranian and is available in neighbouring Kurdish varieties. Here, the EP is restricted to the past transitive tense; the possessive NP is the direct object argument of the clause, and there is no restriction on the person value of the externally realised PR. In addition, the PR is realised as a verbal person suffix, and its realisation as an affix is linked to the rise of ergativity since the Middle Iranian period.

The second type of EPC is restricted to a 3SG bound PR. Morphologically speaking, this second type of EP cuts across the tense and transitivity of the clause, and the PR is a pronominal clitic. The accessibility of this type of EPC depends partly on the cross-linguistically known ‘affectedness condition’. Therefore, EP is most expected when the PM is a body part and its syntactic relation—included in the verb’s argument structure—is affected by the verb’s action. This results in the accessibility of EPCs—in descending order— with unaccusative subjects, direct objects, and prepositional objects. On the other hand, unergative and transitive subjects are not allowed in the EPC.

What distinguishes Laki is that it has extended the EP to stative verbs such as the copula verb, ‘know’ and ‘remain’. Here, the EPR cannot be accounted for in terms of affectedness condition, suggesting that Laki’s EP might have started with stative verbs (cf. Chappell 1999 for a relevant development in Sinitic languages). In other words, Laki type 2 EPCs are sensitive to the affectedness feature— in the case of affected semantic roles— and to the stative feature— relevant for copula clauses which regularly allow EP.

Laki type 2 EPCs also highlight the primacy of the body part concept in external possession. As seen in 5.4. a body part PM functioning as a direct object is still accessible to EP even if the verb is not patient-affecting.

The restriction of EPR to the 3SG person was said to probably reflect the frequency of the third person in affected semantic roles. If confirmed, this could open up new insights into the intersection of person values with external possession due to their syntactic functions. Alternatively, it was proposed that the grammaticalisation of the 3SG person clitic and its loss of mobility could justify EP in a subset of constructions, e.g., copula clauses.

Finally, Haspelmath (1999) suggests that the Dative External possessor was presumably a genetic feature of the Indo-European family but has been retained only in the Standard Average European Sprachbund. The findings of this paper show that Dative external possessors similar to the Average European Sprachbund are not only found in Laki but show rarities not attested elsewhere in Indo-European.

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Abbreviations

A	past transitive subject
ACC	accusative
ADD	additive
ASP	verbal aspectual particle
CLF	classifier
COP	copula
DAT	dative
DEF	definite
DEM	demonstrative DRCT directional particle EPepenthetic
F	feminine
GEN	genitive

IND	indicative	INDF	indefinite	INF	infinitive	IPFV	imperfective	IRR	irrealis
NC	non-canonical subject								
O	object								
NP	noun phrase								
PL	plural								
POSS	possessor								
POST	postposition								
PRF	perfect								
PRS	present								
PST	past								
PVB	preverbal derivational formative								
R	adpositional complement								

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